Rikki-Tikki-Tavi

by Rudyard Kipling (England, 1894)

This is Kipling's story of a heroic young mongoose that saves an English family from a pair of vengeful cobras. Originally from *The Jungle Book*, it gives young people an introduction to British-occupied India and young actors the opportunity to experiment with characterization. It's a good story for looking at "perspective." Consider incorporating flutes (recorders) into the beginning and end of the snake charmers' narration.



Cast of Characters

Snake Charmer 1

Snake Charmer 2

Teddy: An English boy living in India

Alice: Teddy's mother

Big Man: Teddy's father

Rikki-Tikki-Tavi: A heroic mongoose

Darzee: A songbird

Deezar: Another songbird, Darzee's wife

Nag: A hooded king cobra

Nagaina: Another hooded king cobra, Nag's wife

Chuchundra: The fearful muskrat

Chorus: Darzee and others

Vocabulary

bungalow	roaming	triumph	tuft	brood
curiosity	stealthily	valiant	scuttled	quivered

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Scene 1: A Bungalow in India

SNAKE CHARMER 1: This is the story of the great war Rikki-tikki-tavi fought throughout the rooms and garden of a big bungalow in India.

SNAKE CHARMER 2: When Rikki-Tikki was very young, a flood washed him out of his burrow and carried him down a ditch to the middle of a garden.

TEDDY: Look, Mother, here's a dead mongoose. We should give him a proper funeral.

ALICE: Perhaps he isn't really dead, Teddy. Let's dry him off.

BIG MAN: He's not dead—just half choked. Now don't frighten him, and we'll see what he'll do once he's warmed up a bit.

SNAKE CHARMER 1: Soon Rikki was himself again and, like all mongooses, he was eaten up with curiosity.

SNAKE CHARMER 2: The mongoose motto is "Run and find out," so within moments Rikki had run around the entire room, and then he jumped on the boy's shoulder.

BIG MAN: Don't be frightened, Teddy. That's how he makes friends.

TEDDY: *Ouch!* He's tickling me.

RIKKI: *Rikk-tikk-tikki!*

ALICE: Good gracious, he's a wild creature! I suppose he's tame only because we've been kind to him.

BIG MAN: Every mongoose is like that. As long as Teddy doesn't pick him up by the tail, he'll run in and out of the house all day long.

RIKKI *(aside)*: There is much to find out about this family. I shall certainly *stay* and find out.

SNAKE CHARMER 1: Rikki spent all that day roaming the house.

SNAKE CHARMER 2: And when Teddy went to bed, Rikki-tikki climbed up, too.

ALICE: I don't like that. He may bite the child.

BIG MAN: He'll do no such thing. Having a mongoose around is the surest way to protect against deadly snakes. Why, if one came into the room right now . . .

Think About It

What is the setting of this story?

ALICE: *Shhh!* I don't want to think of anything so awful. Snakes are the one thing I hate about India.

SNAKE CHARMER 1: And well she should, for a cobra inside the garden walls brings danger and death.

Scene 2: The Bungalow Garden

SNAKE CHARMER 1: The next morning, Rikki met Darzee, the songbird, sitting on the edge of his nest, crying softly.

RIKKI: What is the matter?

DARZEE: Yesterday, one of our babies fell out of the nest, and Nag ate him.

RIKKI: That is terrible! Who is this Nag?

NAG: *Hissss.* Who is Nag? I am Nag. *Hissss* . . . look, and be afraid!

SNAKE CHARMER 2: Out from the brush came a huge cobra, spreading its massive hood.

SNAKE CHARMER 1: Rikki knew a cobra's business is death.

SNAKE CHARMER 2: But a mongoose can't stay frightened for long. Rikki knew a mongoose's business is to fight snakes.

RIKKI: Well, cobra or no cobra, do you think it is right for you to eat baby birds?

SNAKE CHARMER 1: Nag watched the grass behind Rikki, hoping to catch Rikki off his guard.

NAG: *Hissss* . . . let us talk. You eat eggs. Why shouldn't I eat birds?

DEEZAR: Behind you! Look behind you.

SNAKE CHARMER 2: Rikki jumped up in the air as the head of Nagaina, Nag's terrible wife, whizzed past below him.

NAG: *Hiss.* Wicked, wicked birds!

SNAKE CHARMER 1: Rikki's eyes grew red and hot. He sat back on his tail and hind legs and chattered with rage.

RIKKI: *Rikk-tikk-tikki!*

SNAKE CHARMER 2: But Nag and Nagaina disappeared into the grass.

Think About It

Thus begins the conflict. What is the conflict in this story?

Think About It

If Rikki eats eggs, why shouldn't Nag eat birds? If you were Rikki, how would you answer this question?

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Scene 3: The Garden and Bungalow, at Night

SNAKE CHARMER 1: That night, Rikki went out in the dark and bumped into Chuchundra, the muskrat.

CHUCHUNDRA *(whimpering)*: *Errh,* please don't hurt me, Rikki-tikki!

RIKKI: Why would a snake-hunter hurt a muskrat?

CHUCHUNDRA: *Errh,* how am I to be sure some dark night Nag won't mistake me for you?

RIKKI: I will take care of Nag.

CHUCHUNDRA: *Errh,* but those who kill snakes get killed by snakes. Then what? Nag is everywhere, Rikki-tikki.

RIKKI: What do you mean by that?

CHUCHUNDRA: *Errh,* I mustn't tell you anything, but can't you hear, Rikki-tikki?

SNAKE CHARMER 2: Rikki listened. He could just catch the faintest *scratch-scratch* of a snake on brickwork.

RIKKI: That's Nag or Nagaina crawling into one of the bathrooms!

SNAKE CHARMER 1: Rikki stole off to the bathroom in the bungalow.

SNAKE CHARMER 2: At the bottom of the wall, there was a brick pulled out for the pipes. Rikki listened. On the other side, Nag and Nagaina were whispering.

NAGAINA: *Hisss.* Go in quietly. Remember that the Big Man is the first one to bite. Then we will hunt for Rikki-tikki together. *Hisss . . .*

NAG: *Hisss.* Are you sure there is something to be gained by attacking the people?

NAGAINA: When the house is emptied of people, Rikki will have to go away, and we will rule the garden. *Hisss.* When our eggs hatch, our young snakes will need room and quiet.

SNAKE CHARMER 1: Rikki tingled with rage. Then he saw Nag's head come stealthily through the hole.

RIKKI *(aside)*: If I strike him here, Nagaina will know, but if I fight him on the open floor, the odds are in his favor. What am I to do?

Think About It

How does the character of Rikki compare to the character of Chuchundra? How is Chuchundra's character important to the story?

SNAKE CHARMER 2: Nag waved to and fro, and then Rikki heard him drinking from the big water jar that was used to fill the bath.

NAG: Ah, that is good. *Hissss.* Now, I shall wait here till the Big Man comes in the morning. Nagaina, do you hear me? I shall wait here in the cool till daytime. Then I will strike.

SNAKE CHARMER 1: There was no answer from outside, so Rikki knew Nagaina had gone away.

SNAKE CHARMER 2: Nag hid by the water jar, but Rikki stayed still. After an hour, he began to move, muscle by muscle, toward the jar.

RIKKI: At last, Nag is asleep. I must aim for the head, and once I am there, I must not let go. O, Rikki!

CHORUS: *At the hole where he went in*
Red-Eye called to Wrinkle-Skin.
Hear what little Red-Eye saith:
Nag, come up and dance with death!

RIKKI: *Rikk-tikk-tikki!*

SNAKE CHARMER 1: Rikki jumped. He bit and held on. He was battered to and fro as a rat is shaken by a dog, but he did not let go.

SNAKE CHARMER 2: The noise of Rikki being thrown about the bathroom woke the family. The Big Man came in with his gun, but Nag was already dead.

BIG MAN: It's the mongoose again, Alice. The little chap has saved our lives now.

RIKKI: I must get some rest if I am to settle with Nagaina. She will be worse than five Nags, and there's no knowing when her eggs will hatch.

Think About It

How is the water jar a clue to the story's time setting?

Think About It

Why is Rikki worried about Nagaina's eggs hatching?

Scene 4: The Garden, the Next Morning

SNAKE CHARMER 1: In the morning, news of Nag's death was all over the garden. Darzee chirped a song of triumph at the top of his voice.

DARZEE: *Who hath delivered us, who?*
Tell me his nest and his name.
Rikki, the valiant, the true,
Tikki, with eyeballs of flame . . .

RIKKI: You silly tuft of feathers! Is this any time to sing?

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DARZEE: *Give him the Thanks of the birds,*
Bowing with tail-feathers spread!
Praise him with nightingale-words,
Nay, I will praise him instead.

RIKKI: Are you listening to me, Darzee?

DARZEE: Nag is dead! He will never eat our babies again.

RIKKI: That's true enough, but what about Nagaina?

DARZEE: Nagaina called for Nag, but the Big Man tossed him upon the rubbish heap. Let us sing about the great, the red-eyed Rikki-tikki!

Who hath delivered us, who? . . .

RIKKI: Stop singing a minute, Darzee. You're safe enough in your nest there, but it's war for me down here.

DARZEE: For the great, the beautiful Rikki-tikki's sake I will stop. What is it, O Killer of the Terrible Nag?

RIKKI: Where does Nagaina keep her eggs?

DARZEE: In the melon bed. She hid them there weeks ago.

RIKKI: Fly off to the stables and pretend your wing is broken, and let Nagaina chase you away. I must get to the melon bed, and if I went there now she'd see me.

SNAKE CHARMER 2: Darzee was a feather-brained fellow, but his wife knew that cobra's eggs meant young cobras later on, so she flew off to trick Nagaina.

SNAKE CHARMER 1: When Deezar found Nagaina, she fluttered in front of the snake and cried out.

DEEZAR: Oh, my wing is broken! The boy in the house threw a stone at me and broke it.

SNAKE CHARMER 2: Then she fluttered more desperately than ever.

NAGAINA: *Hisss.* You warned Rikki-tikki when I would have struck him. You've chosen a bad time to be lame.

DEEZAR: The boy broke it with a stone!

NAGAINA: Before night, the boy will lie very still. *Hisss.* What is the use of running away? I am sure to catch you. Little fool, look at me!

SNAKE CHARMER 1: Darzee's wife knew better, for a bird who looks at a snake's eyes gets so frightened that she cannot move.

Think About It

Is this story realistic or unrealistic? How do you know?

SNAKE CHARMER 2: Deezar fluttered along the ground, piping sorrowfully, and the snake quickened her pace.

SNAKE CHARMER 1: Once Rikki heard them going up the path, he raced to find Nagaina's eggs.

RIKKI: I am not a day too soon. The minute these hatch, they could each kill a man or a mongoose!

SNAKE CHARMER 2: A few minutes later, he heard Deezar screaming.

DEEZAR: Rikki-tikki, I led Nagaina down the path, and she has gone into the bungalow, and—oh, come quickly—she means to strike!

SNAKE CHARMER 1: Rikki took the last egg in his mouth and scuttled to the house.

Think About It

This play is a good example of *personification*. What do you think personification might mean?

Scene 5: The Bungalow and Garden

SNAKE CHARMER 1: Inside the bungalow, the family was just gathering for breakfast.

TEDDY: What are we having today, Mother? Something delightful, I hope.

ALICE: Isn't everything delightful in India? Especially after such a scare!

BIG MAN: Teddy, don't move!

ALICE: What is it?

BIG MAN: There's a cobra under Teddy's chair. Stay still, Teddy. Whatever you do, don't move!

NAGAINA: *Hisss.* Yes, stay still, son of the Big Man that killed Nag. If you move, I strike, and if you do not move, I strike. Oh, foolish people who killed my Nag!

SNAKE CHARMER 2: It was then that Rikki entered the room.

RIKKI: Turn around, Nagaina. Turn and fight!

NAGAINA: All in good time. I will settle my account with you shortly. *Hisss.* Look at your friends, Rikki-tikki. They are afraid. If you come a step nearer, I strike.

RIKKI: Look at your eggs in the melon bed. Go and look, Nagaina.

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SNAKE CHARMER 1: The big snake turned half round and saw the one egg Rikki had brought with him.

NAGAINA: *Ah-h!* Give it to me.

RIKKI: What price for a snake's egg? For a young king cobra? For the last, the very last of the brood?

SNAKE CHARMER 2: Nagaina spun clear round, forgetting everything for the sake of the one egg.

SNAKE CHARMER 1: Teddy's father shot out a big hand, caught Teddy by the shoulder, and dragged him across the table, out of reach of Nagaina.

RIKKI: Tricked! Tricked! Tricked! *Rikk-tikk-tikk!* The boy is safe, and it was I—I who caught Nag by the hood last night in the bathroom.

SNAKE CHARMER 2: Then he began to jump, all four feet together, his head close to the floor.

RIKKI: It was over before the Big Man came. I did it. *Rikk-tikk-tikki!* Come, Nagaina, come and fight with me.

NAGAINA: Give me the egg! *Hisss.* Give me the last of my eggs, and I will go away.

RIKKI: Yes, you will go away, and you will never come back. Fight, widow! Fight!

CHORUS: *Eye to eye and head to head,*
This shall end when one is dead;
Turn for turn and twist for twist—
Hah! The hooded Death has missed!

SNAKE CHARMER 1: Rikki-tikki was staying just out of reach of Nagaina's bite, his little eyes like hot coals.

RIKKI: *Rikk-tikk-tikki!*

SNAKE CHARMER 2: Again and again she struck, each time coming within a whisker of Rikki.

RIKKI: *Rikk-tikk-tikki!*

SNAKE CHARMER 1: The egg still lay on the floor, till at last Nagaina snatched it in her mouth and flew like an arrow down the path with Rikki-tikki right behind her.

TEDDY: There, Father, the snake has gone into that hole! Rikki's little white teeth were clenched on her tail, and he went down with her!

Think About It

From whose *perspective* do we see this story? Would the story be different from Nagaina's perspective? How? What about the other characters?

BIG MAN: We can only hope he survives. Very few mongooses care to follow a cobra into its hole. In the dark, they never know when it might open out and give the cobra room to turn and strike.

ALICE: Oh, how very awful!

SNAKE CHARMER 2: The family watched and listened, but for a long time all was silent down the hole.

DARZEE: It is all over for Rikki-tikki! We must sing his death song, for Nagaina has surely killed him underground. Valiant Rikki-tikki is dead!

SNAKE CHARMER 2: Darzee cleared his throat and bowed his head when, suddenly, the grass by the hole quivered.

TEDDY: Here he is! Here is our Rikki at last!

ALICE: Why, hooray! Our mongoose has done it again!

RIKKI: It is all over. Nagaina will never come out again.

SNAKE CHARMER 1: This set everyone in the garden singing.

CHORUS: *Give him the Thanks of the birds,*
Bowing with tail-feathers spread!
Praise him with nightingale-words,
Nay, I will praise him instead.

SNAKE CHARMER 2: Rikki-tikki had a right to be proud of himself—but he did not grow too proud.

SNAKE CHARMER 1: And he kept that garden as a mongoose should keep it, with tooth and jump and spring and bit, till never a cobra dared show its head inside the walls.

CHORUS: *Who hath delivered us, who?*
Tell me his nest and his name.
Rikki, the valiant, the true,
Tikki, with eyeballs of flame!



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Name: _____ Date: _____

Literary Elements/Story Discussion

1. **What is the title of the story?**

2. **Who is the author?**

3. **Setting:** When and where does the story happen?

4. **Main character:** Who is the story about?

5. **Conflict:** What is the main character's problem?

6. **Resolution:** How does the main character fix the problem?

7. **Theme:** What is the universal idea behind the story?

8. **Moral:** What lesson are we supposed to learn from the story?

9. **Realism:** Is the story realistic or unrealistic? What evidence is there?

10. **Plot:** Retell or summarize the main events of the story in just a few sentences.

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Play Performance Scoring Guide

Student: _____ Date: _____ Grade Level: _____

Play: _____ Part: _____

	Fluency	Delivery	Stage Presence	Comprehension
Exceeds expectations	✳ Reads without error ✳ Intonation and expression consistently appropriate to character	✳ Consistently appropriate volume ✳ Pacing as if speaking naturally	✳ Projects toward audience ✳ Memorizes lines ✳ Acts and puts character in voice, speaks with accent, etc. ✳ Recognizes cues without prompting ✳ Demonstrates leadership when practicing/performing ✳ May incorporate props where appropriate	✳ Able to identify and elaborate on literary elements and performance objections during discussion and assessment activities
Meets expectations	✳ Reads with minimal errors ✳ Some intonation and expressiveness	✳ Appropriately loud volume ✳ Consistent pacing	✳ Consistently faces audience ✳ Holds script away from face ✳ Attempts to act with voice characterization, etc. ✳ Follows along, recognizes cues ✳ Demonstrates cooperation when practicing	✳ Able to identify most literary elements and performance objectives during assessment activities ✳ Participates in discussions
Does not yet meet expectations	✳ Frequency or nature of errors suggests need for more practice ✳ Frequent stumbles, flat intonation, or lack of expression	✳ Too quiet ✳ Choppy or rushed pacing	✳ Tends to turn back to audience ✳ Tends to speak into script ✳ Does not add character—just reads lines ✳ Loses place, misses cues ✳ Tends to be unprepared or unfocused	✳ Does not participate in discussions ✳ Unable to identify most literary elements or performance objectives

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Discussion Questions Answer Key

Rikki-Tikki-Tavi (page 46)

Page 47

This story takes place during the era of England's occupation of India (1800s) in the bungalow of English citizens working there.

Page 48 (top)

Cobras are too dangerous for the garden; Rikki must protect the garden's residents.

Page 48 (bottom)

Answers will vary. Some students may talk about "the natural order" and "the circle of life." Others may talk about birds already being "alive." Some creative thinker might answer, "Rikk-tikk-tikki."

Page 49

Rikki is presented as brave or valiant, while Chuchundra is weak and frightened. Chuchundra's character is meant to show that the garden creatures live in constant fear of the cobras.

Page 50 (top)

The water jar shows that this story happened in the distant past, before people had houses with full plumbing.

Page 50 (bottom)

Snake eggs hatch into snakes, which will be just as dangerous as their parents.

Page 51

The story is unrealistic because the animals talk to one another, although from the perspective of the Big Man and his family, who conceivably hear only chattering from the creatures, it could be construed as realistic.

Page 52

Personification means non-humans demonstrating human emotions and traits. The animals talking and thinking like humans is a form of personification.

Page 53

Most of the story is from Rikki's perspective (although the family's perspective is also seen, such as in scenes 1 and 5). The story is much different from the perspective of the cobras.

Page 54

One theme is courage. Rikki fights the cobras and defends the garden. His courage leads to him becoming a hero.

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